

GUIDE 4 OF THE PARENT SERIES

Sharing & Sibling Conflict

A parent's field guide to sibling rivalry, fighting over toys and attention, and teaching real sharing — for children ages 1–12, without forcing false harmony or playing favorites.



BEFORE YOU START

About this guide

"Mine!" "That's not fair!" "She started it!" — and it's not even lunchtime yet. If refereeing your kids feels like a full-time job, you're not raising children who don't get along. You're raising normal siblings. This guide explains why some rivalry is developmentally expected — even healthy — what's realistic to expect at each age, and a simple four-step way to step into a fight without picking a side.

What's inside

Why siblings compete over toys, space, and your attention in the first place, what's realistic to expect at each age as fairness and self-control are still under construction, a simple four-step method for mediating conflict in the moment, ready-to-use scripts, the habits that quietly make rivalry worse, and how to build a household rhythm where fighting isn't the only way your kids get noticed.

The approach behind it

This guide draws on developmental psychologist Laurie Kramer's decades of research on sibling relationship quality and her conflict-coaching curriculum for children, American Academy of Pediatrics guidance on sibling rivalry, Cleveland Clinic parenting resources on managing fights between children, and the Gottman Institute's emotion-coaching approach, applied here to conflict between siblings rather than between a parent and one child alone. Full sources are listed at the end.

Continuing the series

This is Guide 4 of the Peep & Beyond Parent Series. In Guide 1, *When Your Child Hits or Loses Their Temper*, we introduced the "upstairs/downstairs brain" and the C.A.L.M. Path — especially relevant here, since sibling conflict can turn physical faster than almost any other kind. In Guide 2, *Screens & Big Feelings*, we covered the P.A.C.E. Method for hard transitions. This guide adds a third tool for one of the most constant flashpoints in a multi-child household.

A note before you continue: This guide is educational and is not a substitute for medical or mental-health advice. If you're concerned about aggression, bullying dynamics, or your child's wellbeing, please speak with your pediatrician or a licensed child psychologist — reaching out is a sign of good parenting, not a failure of it.

CONTENTS

What you'll find inside

01	Why Siblings Fight	04
	The developmental reasons behind rivalry — and why some of it is healthy	
02	What's Realistic, By Age	05
	Sharing capacity and typical conflict patterns for toddlers, preschoolers, and school-age kids	
03	The S.H.A.R.E. Method	07
	A simple four-step way to mediate a fight without picking a side	
04	Scripts You Can Use	09
	Exact words by age, for stepping in and coaching a repair	
05	Common Mistakes	10
	Habits that quietly make sibling rivalry worse	
06	Building a Calmer Household Rhythm	11
	One-on-one time, fair-not-equal, and turn-taking systems that don't need you	
07	When to Reach Out	13
	Signs it's worth a conversation with a professional	
08	Quick Reference Sheet	14
	One page to print and keep on the fridge	

SECTION 01

Why Siblings Fight

Two children competing over one toy, one lap, or one parent's attention isn't a sign that something's wrong at home. It's what happens when two people still learning to regulate emotions share close quarters and a limited supply of things they each want.

Competing for a resource that can't be split

Attention is the resource siblings fight over most, even when the fight looks like it's about a toy. You cannot read two bedtime stories at once — and children notice every time that math doesn't favor them. A toy dispute is often the visible tip of a quieter competition for you.

Layered on top is a fairness sense still under construction. Young children track outcomes, not intent — "he got more" registers as unfair even when the reasons are sound to an adult. That instinct isn't a character flaw; it's how a developing brain measures fairness.

RESEARCH NOTE

Developmental psychologist Laurie Kramer, whose sibling-relationship research at the University of Illinois and now Northeastern University shapes programs used with families nationally, has found that children who learn to negotiate and repair conflict with a sibling early carry those skills into friendships and adult relationships. Handled well, sibling conflict does real relational work — not just noise.

Some rivalry is normal — and even useful

A certain amount of bickering is one of the most consistent findings in sibling research, across family structures and cultures. It isn't evidence of poor parenting — a sibling is often the first person a child practices disagreeing with, and making up with, safely and over again.

KEEP IN MIND

Fighting with a sibling isn't proof your children "don't get along." For most families, it's the training ground where negotiation and repair get practiced long before they're needed anywhere else.

SECTION 02

What's Realistic, By Age

"Just share" means something completely different to a two-year-old than it does to a ten-year-old. Here's what's actually within reach at each stage — and what typically triggers conflict there.

TODDLERS · AGES 1–3

Toddlers genuinely cannot understand sharing yet as a two-way exchange. At this age, "mine" is less about selfishness and more about a child figuring out where they end and the world begins — possession is one of the first ways a toddler practices having a self at all. Grabbing, refusing to hand things over, and short, intense flare-ups over a single toy are expected, not misbehavior.

Toddlers also play mostly *alongside* each other rather than truly together, so conflict often erupts the moment one child's solo play crosses into another's space — not because either one is being unkind, but because "taking turns" isn't a concept their brains can hold onto yet.

What helps most: managing the environment (duplicate favorite toys where you can), narrating rather than lecturing ("You both want the truck"), and not expecting an apology to be sincere or a toy handover to be voluntary — a gentle redirect works better than a lesson at this age.

PRESCHOOL • AGES 3–6

Preschoolers begin to grasp turn-taking, but only with heavy adult scaffolding — a timer, a visible line, a reminder of whose turn is next. Empathy is emerging but inconsistent, so a child can comfort a crying sibling one minute and knock down their tower the next. This is also the age jealousy starts showing up around attention and praise, not just objects — a sibling being hugged, helped, or complimented can trigger conflict as easily as a shared toy.

"Fair" starts to matter a great deal here, but preschoolers judge fairness almost entirely by outcome, not process — identical portions matter more than the reasons behind any difference. Expect real, frequent squabbles over turns, attention, and who got "more," alongside genuine flashes of affection.

What helps most: visible turn-taking systems (a timer, a simple chart), praising specific cooperative moments right when they happen, and not forcing hugs or scripted apologies that a preschooler doesn't yet feel.

SCHOOL AGE • AGES 6–12

By school age, children are capable of real perspective-taking and can problem-solve conflict with coaching rather than needing a parent to hand down every verdict. Fights shift too — less often about a single toy, more often about space, screen turns, being treated fairly versus identically, being embarrassed in front of friends, or comparisons between siblings' grades, sports, or attention.

This is the age where kids can genuinely help design the household agreements that reduce conflict, and where "fair but not equal" starts to make real sense to them if it's explained rather than just declared.

What helps most: inviting them into solving repeat conflicts instead of just refereeing each one, giving each child clear ownership over their own space or belongings, and coaching a resolution rather than delivering one.

SECTION 03

The S.H.A.R.E. Method

A simple four-step way to step into a fight between siblings — built to help both children feel heard, not to hand down a quick verdict about who was right.

1

Separate — cool the moment down first

Before anyone talks, create a little physical and emotional space — take the disputed item out of reach for a moment, or simply crouch between the two children. This isn't a punishment; it's a pause. Neither child can actually hear a word you say while their body is still flooded with the heat of the fight, so this step buys the calm the next one needs.

2

Hear both sides — one voice at a time

Ask each child to say what happened, uninterrupted, while you hold up a hand for the other to wait their turn. Resist the urge to referee based on who got to you first or who's crying loudest — that only teaches your children that speed or volume wins arguments, not fairness.

3

Agree on a next step — coach, don't rule

Instead of announcing a verdict, ask both children what they think would be fair: a timer, a trade, taking turns going first next time. School-age kids can usually generate a workable plan themselves with a little coaching; younger children need you to offer two acceptable choices and let them pick. Either way, the goal is a solution they had a hand in, not one handed to them.

4

Reconnect — follow up and notice repair

Once the immediate fight has settled, circle back a little later — not to relitigate it, but to notice out loud when the plan worked, or when the two of them played well together afterward. This is the step most parents skip once the crying stops, and it's the one that actually reinforces the skill for next time.

RESEARCH NOTE

Laurie Kramer's "More Fun With Sisters and Brothers" program, which coaches children directly in conflict-resolution skills with a sibling, has been shown in university studies to reduce the frequency and intensity of sibling conflict and increase positive interactions afterward — evidence that mediating conflict well is a teachable skill, not a fixed trait some sibling pairs simply lack.

SECTION 04

Scripts You Can Use

A few ready phrases, by age, for stepping into a fight and coaching a repair afterward.

AGE	STEPPING IN	COACHING A REPAIR
Toddler 1–3	"Two hands, one truck. Let's find the other one." <i>(Redirect, don't lecture.)</i>	"You both wanted it. That's hard." Hold gently, offer a swap, keep words short.
Preschool 3–6	"You're both upset — I'll hear one, then the other."	"It's your turn, then your turn. I'll set the timer so it's fair."
School age 6–12	"I'm not choosing sides. Tell me what happened, then you tell me."	"You two come up with a plan — I'll check back in five minutes."

TIP

Try not to assume the older child is automatically "the one who should know better," or that tears automatically mean the other child is at fault — both habits quietly teach one child that fairness doesn't apply to them.

SECTION 05

Common Mistakes

Every one of these is an understandable response to a loud, tiring moment — most parents have reached for all of them. Here's what tends to help less than it seems like it should, and what to try instead.

Tends to backfire

- Always blaming the older child "because they should know better"
- Forcing an instant apology or hug neither child means
- Comparing siblings out loud ("Why can't you be more like...")
- Automatically believing whoever cries first or loudest
- Making one child the built-in babysitter or peacekeeper
- Ruling on a fight before hearing both sides
- Rewarding tattling with immediate attention

Works better

- Hearing both sides before responding, every time
- Letting apologies be real, even if that takes a little longer
- Praising each child for their own strengths, separately
- Watching for patterns over time before assuming who's "at fault"
- Giving each child their own age-appropriate responsibilities
- Pausing to ask "what happened?" before deciding anything
- Coaching direct communication between them instead

RESEARCH NOTE

Cleveland Clinic child-development specialists note that automatically siding with the younger or more upset-looking child teaches both children the wrong lesson: the younger one learns that crying settles arguments, and the older one learns that fairness simply doesn't apply to them — a pattern that can deepen resentment between siblings over years, not just in the moment.

SECTION 06

Building a Calmer Household Rhythm

The goal isn't a household where siblings never fight — that's not realistic, and chasing it often makes things worse. The goal is a rhythm where fighting isn't the only reliable way to get your attention.

One-on-one time, even five minutes

Much sibling conflict is a scramble for individual attention wearing a toy-shaped disguise. Short, predictable, undivided time with each child — even five or ten minutes a day, doing something that child chooses — reliably reduces attention-seeking conflict, because it stops attention from feeling like a scarce resource worth fighting over.

Fair, not identical

Trying to make everything perfectly equal — same size slice, same number of turns, same bedtime regardless of age — is exhausting to maintain and teaches children to keep score rather than trust you. Saying the quiet part out loud ("fair doesn't always mean the same, because you two aren't the same age") does more long-term good than any tally chart.

Turn-taking systems that don't need you

A visible timer, a simple rotating chart for who picks the show or sits where in the car, or a shared calendar for a coveted item takes you out of the referee seat for the small, repeat disputes — freeing you to focus on the conflicts that actually need your coaching.

Let them work it out sometimes

Not every squabble needs a parent mediator. When the disagreement is low-stakes and no one is being hurt, stepping back and letting siblings attempt their own repair — even clumsily — builds exactly the skill this guide is trying to teach. Stay within earshot, and step in only if it escalates or a child is genuinely stuck.

FROM GUIDE 1 — THIS STILL APPLIES

If a sibling conflict turns physical — hitting, shoving, throwing — treat it as the same "downstairs brain" moment covered in *When Your Child Hits or Loses Their Temper*. Separate the children first, keep everyone safe, and use the C.A.L.M. Path before attempting any conversation about fairness or turns.

Notice the good moments out loud

Sibling teams that play, build, or laugh together for ten quiet minutes rarely get any comment — it's the fighting that reliably gets noticed and named. Naming the good moments just as specifically ("You two figured that out together — that was teamwork") teaches children that cooperation gets attention too, not just conflict.

SECTION 07

When to Reach Out

Everyday bickering is a normal, expected part of growing up alongside a sibling. A few patterns are worth a conversation with your pediatrician or a licensed child psychologist:

- One child is consistently the target — of teasing, exclusion, or aggression — rather than conflict going both directions
- Fights are frequently severe, physical, or dangerous, even after consistent mediation and calm-down support
- A child seems fearful of a sibling, or their behavior changes noticeably around them
- What looks like rivalry has signs of a bullying dynamic: secrecy, intimidation, or a consistent power imbalance
- You notice a real, ongoing pattern of favoritism in the household that you're struggling to correct on your own

PLEASE REMEMBER

Reaching out for support is not a sign that you've failed as a parent — it's one of the most effective things you can do for your children. A pediatrician or child psychologist can help sort out what's typical rivalry and what needs a more structured plan.

SECTION 08 · PRINT & KEEP

Quick Reference

Keep this page on the fridge for the next sibling squabble.

The S.H.A.R.E. Method

1. **Separate** — cool the moment down
2. **Hear both sides** — one voice at a time
3. **Agree** — coach a solution together
4. **Reconnect** — follow up and notice repair

Say this

"I'm not choosing sides."
"You both wanted it. That's hard."
"What do you two think is fair?"

Skip this

Blaming the older one by default · forced apologies · comparing siblings · ruling before hearing both sides

Remember

Fair beats identical. One-on-one time prevents more fights than any rule. Notice the teamwork, not just the conflict.

Reach out if...

One child is consistently the target · fights are frequently physical or severe · you notice signs of a bullying dynamic → talk to your pediatrician or a child psychologist.

SOURCES & FURTHER READING

Where this guide comes from

Kramer, L., Northeastern University / University of Illinois. Research on sibling relationship quality, and the "More Fun With Sisters and Brothers" conflict-coaching program for children.

American Academy of Pediatrics / HealthyChildren.org. Guidance on sibling rivalry and social development in preschool and school-age children.

Cleveland Clinic. "10 Tips for Dealing With Sibling Rivalry" — practical guidance for parents on managing conflict between children.

The Gottman Institute. Emotion-coaching framework, applied here to conflict between siblings.

American Psychological Association. Research coverage on siblings' lifelong influence on relationship and social skills.

This guide is part of the Peep & Beyond Parent Series, created to give parents clear, research-informed support for the everyday moments of raising kids — together, under one roof. It is educational in nature and does not replace individualized medical or mental-health care.

With you, one shared toy at a time.

— Peep & Beyond